

**BIMCO: The practical voice of shipping**

**Sharpening your focus: Securing the safety of you  
and your ship**

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MPA International Safety@Sea Week 2025



# Distraction





# BIMCO





## Examples of Distraction-Related Incidents

### Collision of Scot Carrier and Karin Høj

Occurred on 13 December 2021 in Swedish waters

Resulted in capsizing and deaths of two crew members of the Karin Høj.

Second officer on Scot Carrier was distracted by tablet and alcohol

- <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/scot-carrier-and-karin-hoej-report-published#:~:text=Collision%20between%20a%20general%20cargo,the%20loss%20of%20two%20lives>

# 13 Dec 2021



## Examples of Distraction-Related Incidents

- Collision between Bunun Queen and Thunder
  - Occurred on 23 July 2022
  - Thunder sustained substantial damage and flooding
  - Master of Thunder distracted by cell phone
  - Second officer of Bunun Queen not maintaining lookout
- [https://www.nts.gov/investigations/Pages/DC A22FM030.aspx#:~:text=%E2%80%8BWe%20determined%20that%20the,both%20officers%20from%20keeping%20a](https://www.nts.gov/investigations/Pages/DC%20A22FM030.aspx#:~:text=%E2%80%8BWe%20determined%20that%20the,both%20officers%20from%20keeping%20a)

# 23 Jul 2022

## Others

- Grounding of Ever Forward
- Collision of USCG vessel CG 25889 and Thriller 09
- Collision of tug M/V Caribbean Sea and DUKW34

# Distraction

Distraction and distraction-causing devices had a role to play in all of these incidents, highlighting the importance of managing distraction on board ships to ensure the safety of the crew, the ship and its cargo.

# Guidelines for the management of distraction causing devices on board ships

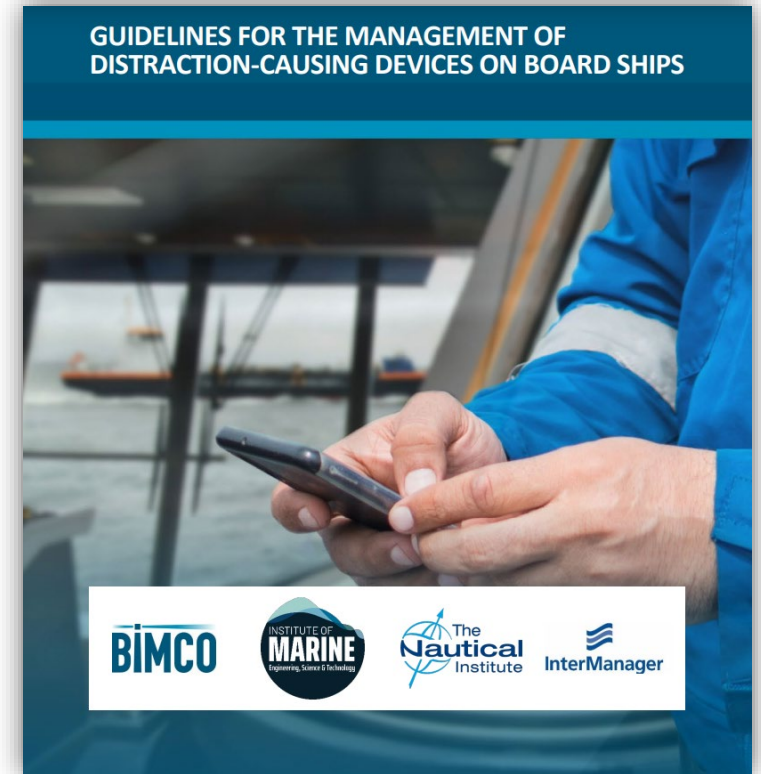


[Distraction-causing devices on board ships](#)

[2025 guidelines for the mgmt of dcd-long-v march2025.pdf](#)

[2025 guidelines for the mgmt of dcd-short-v march2025.pdf](#)

[2025 checklist for the mgmt of dcd-v march2025.pdf](#)





# Definition and Impact



- Interrupts attention
- Prevents concentration on tasks
- Diverts mind to other activities
- Technology and Productivity
  - Decreases productivity
- Research Findings
  - Major concern in safety-critical industries
- Maritime Safety
  - **Distraction leads to unsafe practices**

## Distraction and Governance of DCD in other industries



- Writing a text message, which normally takes 7 seconds, while driving at 50 km per hour is equivalent to driving through the length of a football field without looking at the field
- In most countries, the use of mobile phones while driving is a judicial issue
- In Singapore, using a mobile communication device while driving will attract a fine of up to \$500 but also 12 demerit points.
- Strict laws are in place proscribing use of a mobile phone or other distraction causing devices while driving.
- Should you penalize or not? In road transport it works as a major deterrent



## Process of Distraction

- Human beings are not designed to carry out multi-tasking
- Research shows that when we check something, our mind requires several minutes of refocus time to return to the original task;
- The absence of a DCD helps to avoid the frequent switching of the brain, maintaining focus on the task in hand. When the brain receives information that is unrelated to work, it is more likely to lose focus and, consequently, situational awareness. This raises the risk of accidents.



# Statistics on Distraction



- **Mobile Phone Distractions in the US**
  - Cause at least 2,600 traffic deaths annually
  - Lead to 330,000 accidents with moderate or severe injuries
- **Driving and Distraction**
  - 5 seconds of distraction at 55 mph equals traveling a football field blind
  - Drivers overestimate their multitasking abilities
  - Concern about others' distractions
- **Distractions on Ships**
  - Seafarers perform multiple safety-critical tasks
  - Need for constant situational awareness
  - Potential sources of distraction can lead to loss of focus



# Examples of Distraction



- **Text Messaging**
  - Reading or sending a text message
- **Mobile Phone Usage**
  - Using a mobile phone or prioritising answering a call at an inopportune time
- **Engaging with Media**
  - Engaging with social media or viewing other media
  - Using a navigation system
  - Eating while driving a vehicle
- **Non-Time-Constrained Work Tasks**
  - Indulging in non-important work-related tasks such as chart corrections during critical navigation or collision avoidance tasks
- **Non-Work-Related Tasks**
  - Indulging in non-work-related tasks while carrying out an important task at hand

# Devices Causing Distraction

- Types of Devices
  - Mobile phones
  - Computers (laptops, desktops)
  - Tablets
  - Cameras
  - Smart watches
  - Entertainment devices
- Usage Purposes
  - Personal use
  - **Business use**

# Types of Distraction in Maritime

- Types of Distraction
  - Key personnel using personal DCDs
  - Non-key personnel using personal DCDs
  - Key personnel using business devices excessively



- The IMO International Safety Management (ISM) Code requires companies to develop and maintain policies, procedures and instructions to ensure safe operation of ships. The Code also requires that companies develop safety management systems (SMS), which should **assess all identified risks to its ships**, personnel and environment, and establish appropriate safeguards. Several maritime administrations issue safety advisories on this topic.
- As has been highlighted above, distraction at sea, particularly but not exclusively in relation to the performance of navigational tasks, is a risk that needs to be addressed in the SMS.

# Management of Distraction

- Understanding the hazard
- Assessing if the hazard can evolve into risks
- Identification of potential risk and the impact it could have on the safe operation of the ship
- Assessing available risk/hazard control options
- Choosing the most appropriate option
- Implementation of the chosen risk/hazard control option.

# Understanding the Risks



- Key personnel using a DCD
- Non-key personnel using a DCD at workplace
- Excessive use of business DCD by key-personnel



# Assessing if Hazards Can Evolve into Risks



- **Benchmarking Distraction Management**
  - Determine nature of hazard
  - Assess and control risk
- **Factors to Consider**
  - Propensity of crew to carry mobile phones
  - Communication setup on board
  - Internet access restrictions
  - Time restrictions on internet availability
  - Volume of data usage per crew member
  - Payment for internet usage
  - Business telephone usage
  - Key personnel's use of on-board computer

# Identification of Risk and Impact



- **Evaluation of Existing Hazards**
  - Assessing risks posed by DCDs
  - Using past incidents to understand potential consequences
- **Examples of Risks**
  - Distracted navigator leading to collisions
  - Distracted engineer causing machinery maintenance issues
  - Pollution incidents during bunkering
- **Balancing Business and Safety**
  - Impact of not replying to business emails or calls
- Consequences of Accidents
- Internet Connectivity at Sea
- **Importance of Lookout**

# Available Risk Control Options



- **Restricting Personal DCD Usage in Key Spaces**
  - Bridge, engine control room, cargo control rooms
  - Officer on watch, engineer on watch, gangway watch
- **Restricting Personal DCD Usage During Working Hours**
  - Applicable irrespective of the place
- **Restricting Non-Key Personnel DCD Usage in Key Spaces**
  - Limits distraction caused to key personnel
- **Limiting Business DCD Usage During Working Hours**
  - Applicable in working spaces
- **Optimising Onboard Communication Systems**
  - Setup to limit distraction for crew members
- **Strategic Placement of Computers in Key Spaces**



## Choosing the Most Appropriate Risk Control Option

- Risk Control Options
  - Companies may choose one or more options based on risk analysis
  - Cost versus benefit analysis is crucial
- Insurance Aspect
  - Proper procedures can avoid higher insurance premiums
  - Can reduce liability in case of accidents

# Implementation of Risk Control Option



- Importance of Company Policy on Managing Distractions
- Active implementation and enforcement of the policy is crucial

## Verification of Effective Implementation

- Time-tested verification procedure
  - Ensures effective implementation
- Inclusion in safety management system
  - Safeguards and procedures are audited
  - Non-conformances addressed
  - Appropriate corrective actions taken



# Endorsing Organizations

|                           |
|---------------------------|
| <b>BIMCO</b>              |
| <b>IMarEST</b>            |
| <b>InterManager</b>       |
| <b>Nautical Institute</b> |



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